‘David, I understand what you went through last night. If you want to play, that’s great: I want you to. If you don’t feel sure about it, that’s fine too. I want you to make your own mind up. You know how you feel. Do whatever you think is right.’

I played and we beat Luxembourg 6–0. That meant the game in Poland would decide our fate in the qualifiers. It was a huge game and Kevin was under all sorts of pressure to get the right result. Even so, on the Sunday night before we left, we had the same conversation again.

‘If you need to be close by your family, don’t worry. You don’t have to come over there with us. You can stay here if you need to and look after Victoria and Brooklyn.’

I sat down with Victoria and asked what she thought would be best. My instinct was to stay but she saw the situation for what it was.

‘We’ll be all right. We’ve got people to lookout for us now. This is your job. It’s England. You should go.’

I did; and Victoria was right. It was what I needed to do, even though the game in Warsaw was horrible and ended up being a 0–0 draw. It meant we had to wait a couple of months for the result of a Sweden game, when they beat Poland at home, before we knew we’d made it through to that play-off against the Scots.

By Christmas 1999, things had been decided and, even though it hadn’t been spectacular, England would be going to the European Championships the following summer. New Year 2000, meanwhile, and United were heading off to the other side of the world. As European Cup holders, the club were asked to participate in the first-ever FIFA World Club Championships in Brazil.

It did us a lot of good as a team, being away together for that length of time and getting recharged for the rest of the season back home. We’d have won the Premiership anyway, I think, but we did come back from Brazil in pretty good form. And with half-decent tans as well. As things turned out, it really was like a vacation for me. I got sent off in our first game, against Necaxa of Mexico, which meant I missed the next one and then played just twenty minutes of the last one, against South Melbourne.

It was a horrible feeling, getting a red card for the first time as a United player. I went into a challenge for a high, bouncing ball just near the halfway